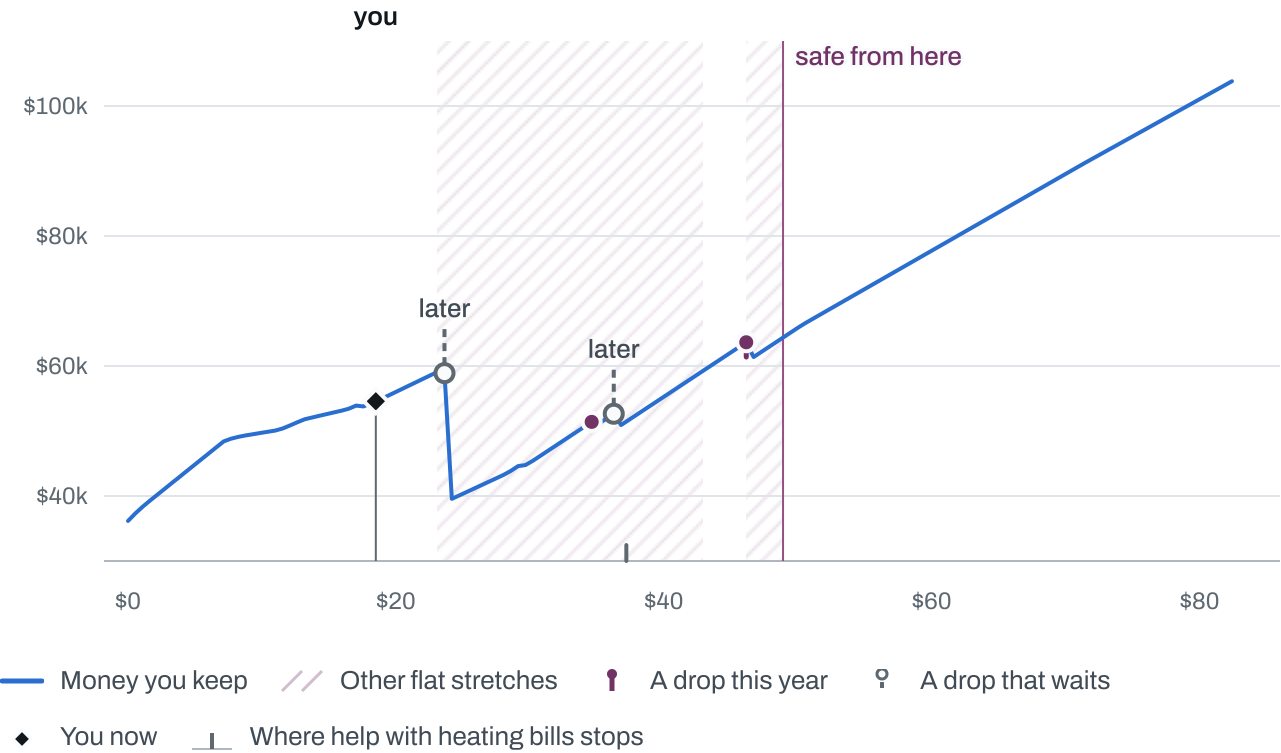


You are paid \$18.50 an hour. You keep \$54,572. Near \$24.25 an hour, more pay can mean less money: past it you would keep about \$19,300 less a year. People call this a benefits cliff. At \$24.25 an hour, free early learning stops: about \$19,300 a year. But not that day. A child in it stays to the end of the next program year.

You keep more than your pay because help and tax money are part of it. \$18,846 of this is free early learning. It is not cash. \$636 a year for your health plan comes out first.

Money you keep in a year, as your pay goes up

Pay is by the hour, at 35 hours a week.



Above \$37.25 an hour, you can no longer apply for help with heating bills in Massachusetts. It is called LIHEAP. It is worth \$355 to \$430 a winter if you get it. About 2 in 10 families who could get it here do.

The picture covers all pay from \$0.00 an hour to \$82.50 an hour. The side numbers start at \$30,000, not at \$0, so the drops are easy to see. These are estimates. They use the rules for 2026 in Massachusetts.

Source: HotGap, from PolicyEngine with 2026 rules. These are your own numbers. Money kept is what is left after taxes and health-plan premiums.

The points the picture marks. Money kept is in dollars a year.

Your pay	You keep	Drop	On the picture
\$18.50 an hour	\$54,572		You now
\$24.25 an hour	\$39,556	-\$19,348	A drop that waits
\$35.25 an hour	\$51,156	-\$247	A drop
\$36.75 an hour	\$50,918	-\$1,735	A drop that waits
\$46.75 an hour	\$61,376	-\$2,273	A drop
\$49.00 an hour	\$64,372		Safe from here

What ends, and when

\$11.50 an hour	Cash help ends. It is called TANF cash assistance.
\$16.50 an hour	Your own free state health plan ends. It is called Medicaid. Then help paying for health insurance starts. It is called the Premium tax credit.
\$18.75 an hour	Waits Your kids' free state health plan would end. It is called Medicaid. It does not end that day. Kids keep it to their next yearly check, up to 12 months later. Then a health plan for kids would start. It is called CHIP.
\$24.25 an hour	Waits Free early learning would end. It is called Head Start. It does not end that day. A child in it stays to the end of the next program year. Food help for moms and babies would end. It is called WIC. Food help would end. It is called SNAP. You would keep about \$19,300 less.
\$28.00 an hour	A tax break for workers would end. It is called the Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC).
\$35.25 an hour	Your health plan would cost more here. You would keep about \$200 less.
\$36.75 an hour	Waits A health plan for kids would end. It is called CHIP. It does not end that day. Kids keep it to their next yearly check, up to 12 months later. Then help paying for health insurance would start. It is called the Premium tax credit. You would keep about \$1,700 less.
\$46.75 an hour	Help paying for health insurance would end. It is called the Premium tax credit. You would keep about \$2,300 less.

What we assumed about you

Rent	None given. We counted no rent.
Child care	None. Nobody in the home pays for day care.
Help you get	Food help (SNAP), cash help (TANF cash assistance), a free state health plan (Medicaid), food help for moms and babies (WIC), and free early learning (Head Start). We count each as if you get it.
Not counted	Child care help (CCDF child care subsidy), housing help (Housing voucher), and help with heating bills (LIHEAP energy assistance). We count them as if you do not get them.
You	Age 30. A U.S. citizen. No one in the home has a disability.
Other money	Savings: None. No child support, SSDI or unemployment pay.
Hours	35 hours a week.
Head Start	Worth \$18,846 a year to you: what day care would cost.
Health plan help	ConnectorCare, up to \$3,646 a year. It helps pay for health insurance. We counted it.
Cash help (TANF)	We used the state's rule for people already on it. Not the first-year rule.

How common is this pay?

About 3 in 10 parents like you in Massachusetts are paid \$18.50 an hour or less. The count could be off by a few thousand dollars either way.

This says how common the pay is. It does not say what you will earn.

From U.S. Census Bureau survey data (ACS 2024, 1-year). Grown to 2026 dollars.

The lowest legal pay

Massachusetts's lowest legal pay is \$15.00 an hour. Full-time work at that pay is about \$31,000 a year.

These are estimates. A case worker decides real help.

We use 2026 rules. The list above says what we assumed. If any of it is wrong for you, these numbers are off too. We did not ask about anyone in the home aged 65 or more.

We do not tell you what to do.